

IN 221 BCE, QIN SHI HUANGDI, the first emperor of China, divided his empire into 36 commanderies on the advice of his minister **Li Ssu**. The dispossessed aristocrats and nobles of Qin's former enemies were moved to the capital Xianyang to keep them under close control. To further encourage a sense of unity, Li Ssu commissioned a single script and a standardized system of weights and measures for China. Further conquests were made to the north and south in 219 and 214 BCE, and thousands of colonists were sent to the new territories. Shi Huangdi dealt firmly with opposition. In 213 BCE, he ordered the "burning of the books," by which the writings of philosophers opposed to the Qin state were burned, and in 212 BCE he had many intellectuals who opposed him brutally killed.



Suppressing opposition

This watercolor-on-silk painting shows Shi Huangdi, China's first emperor, overseeing the burning of books and the execution of scholars.

In the aftermath of the **First Punic War** (see 264–241 BCE), which Sicily and Sardinia lost, Carthage turned its attention to **Spain**. In 238 BCE, **Hamilcar** was sent there, and he conquered almost all of southern Spain. He died in battle against the **Oretani**, a Celtic tribe, in 229 BCE, but by then he had won a **new empire** for Carthage and a strong power base for his family, the **Barcids**.

Despite their victory in the First Punic War, the Romans' position in northern Italy was still weak. In 225 BCE, the Celtic **Insubres and Boii tribes** tried to drive them out. At the **Battle of Telamon**, the Celts were trapped between two Roman armies and routed. Although the Boii accepted defeat in 224 BCE and the Insubres sued for peace two years later, the Romans rebuffed them and pushed on for total victory. The king of the Boii was killed in single combat against a Roman consul, and their capital **Mediolanum** (Milan) captured. The Romans established colonies in the Celtic territories in 218 BCE, including at Piacenza.

A revolt led by **Arsaces** (see 265–241 BCE) in Parthava, a former satrapy in the northeast of the Seleucid Empire, could not be quelled by Seleucus II (r. 246–225 BCE), and a separate **Parthian kingdom emerged** in the region of modern Iran. The Parthians gradually annexed more territory to the west, especially under **Mithridates I** (r. 171–138 BCE). By the early 1st century BCE, only a small area of Syria was under Seleucid control.



This rendition of Hannibal's crossing of the Alps is attributed to Italian artist Jacopo Ripanda. Amazingly, all 37 elephants survived the mountain passage.

Second Punic War

There were three principal theaters of conflict: Spain, Italy, and North Africa. By 203 BCE, the Carthaginians were confined to Africa.

THE SECOND PUNIC WAR 218–202 BCE

- Carthaginian Empire 281 BCE
- Carthaginian territory 200 BCE
- Roman territory 218 BCE
- Roman gains by 200 BCE
- Massalian territory 218 BCE
- Carthaginian victory
- Roman victory
- Hannibal (219–202)
- Hasdrubal (208–207)
- Scipio Africanus (210–206 and 204–202)



ALARMED AT CARTHAGINIAN

EXPANSION IN SPAIN, in 226 BCE the Romans sent an embassy to **Hasdrubal**—son of Hamilcar and the new Barcid commander there—and secured an agreement that the Carthaginians would not move north of the Ebro River. In return, the Romans pledged not to move south—although they did forge alliances with cities in the south, such as Saguntum. In 221 BCE, Hasdrubal was assassinated; two years later, **Hannibal**, his brother and successor, attacked Saguntum, rapidly leading to the **Second Punic War** (219–201 BCE).

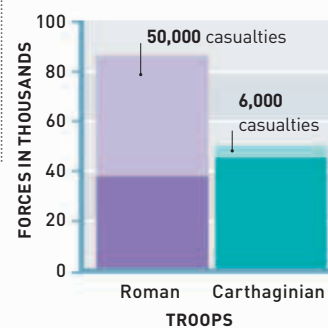
With the prospect of the Romans sending one army to Spain and another via Sicily to invade North Africa, Hannibal

decided to strike first. He marched with 50,000 infantry, 9,000 cavalry, and 37 elephants into northern Spain, across the Pyrenees, through southern Gaul and—to the Romans' astonishment—**crossed the Alps**. Although he now had only around half the force he had started with, his presence encouraged the north Italian Celts to revolt and, at **Trebia** in late 218 BCE, he routed a Roman army. The following year he smashed another large Roman force at **Lake Trasimene**, killing 15,000

Battle of Canae

Some 35,000 Romans survived the battle of Cannae, but half of those were captured by the Carthaginians, and many were sold into slavery.

Romans—including one of the consuls. Faced with many **defections** among the allied cities, the Romans turned to delaying tactics to hold Hannibal at bay. But this was a temporary measure, and the Romans suffered one of their worst ever defeats at **Cannae** in 216 BCE, when



232 BCE Mauryan Empire starts to break up after Ashoka's death

238 BCE Hamilcar Barca reestablishes Carthaginian rule in Spain

231 BCE Seleucus II defeated by Tiridates of Parthia

225 BCE Gallic tribes defeated by Romans at Telamon

223 BCE Antiochus III ascends to Seleucid throne

221 BCE Hannibal becomes Carthaginian commander in Spain

221 BCE The first emperor (Shi Huangdi) unites China under the Qin Dynasty

220 BCE Philip V becomes king of Macedonia

219 BCE Hannibal besieges Saguntum in Spain, beginning the Second Punic War

219 BCE Fourth Syrian War breaks out between Ptolemies and Seleucids over possession of Phoenicia

218 BCE Hannibal crosses the Alps to invade Italy

217 BCE Hannibal triumphs over the Romans at Lake Trasimene

217 BCE Egyptians, led by Ptolemy IV Philopator, crush the Seleucid army under Antiochus III at Raphia, Palestine

216 BCE Hannibal defeats the Romans at Cannae

215 BCE Philip V of Macedonia invades Illyria, starting the First Macedonian War (to 205 BCE)

212 BCE In China, the Qin ban nonscientific books; standardization and simplification of Chinese script

212 BCE Antiochus III campaigns in the east in an unsuccessful attempt to conquer Bactria and Parthia